

MEDIEVAL ROMANCE AND TRADE

Throughout this period clothes for most people were very simple, based on little more than two draped rectangles sewn into a tunic. Tunics and cloaks were made of wool and linen, though leather and furs were also worn, especially in the colder northern regions of Europe. Silk was an extremely expensive item throughout the Medieval period. After the fall of the Roman Empire in 476CE people began to travel across Europe, learning new customs, techniques, and fashions. The Church split into two branches: the Eastern (Byzantine) and the Western (Holy Roman Empire) with different styles of clothing for each. Ecclesiastical clothing was fixed at this time by papal decree and religious vestments today still follow these templates.

New skills and tools

Most people in the Middle Ages wore a variation on a tunic, but, as cutting improved slowly from the 12th to the 14th centuries, clothing became more shaped to the body. Also at this time vertical looms were replaced by horizontal ones, which allowed fabric to be woven more quickly and increased textile production; it became cheaper to buy clothing. Byzantium retained the most advanced and luxurious culture – its clothing styles were much imitated by Western courts and monarchs such as Charlemagne. Europeans travelling to and trading with Near Eastern areas discovered new styles and fabrics, eventually finding out the secrets of sericulture (silk production). Fine lampas, cloth-of-gold, and brocaded silks were produced in Italy and Spain, no longer relying on expensive imports.

Birth of fashion

By the later Middle Ages fashion and clothing became more complicated. There was a wider choice of garments and accessories and a greater range of fabrics; colours were brighter and fastenings more varied. With a certain novelty and more choice, fashion can be said to have been born, styles changed more quickly, and the idea of change for change's sake arrived. Improved production of textiles meant wastage, and innovation was possible. Garment shapes began to be curved, and edges could be snipped or dagged.

Place in society

Despite these changes, some things remained rigid. Women were expected to keep their heads covered, and clothes dictated an individual's place in society – they revealed who you were and what you did. It was frowned upon, and there were even laws against, non-nobility attempting to dress as nobility. At the same time differences between social classes increased – the rich looked a lot richer than the poor.

600–800

664

In England, the Synod of Whitby decides that the Roman tonsure (top of the head shaved) is to be adopted over the Celtic tonsure (front of the head shaved).

▼ Priest being tonsured

801–1070

1071–1100



► Detail from the Bayeux Tapestry



985

Eric the Red sails from Iceland to Greenland with Norse settlers and establishes a colony. Clothing from burials during the 14th and 15th centuries give an insight into dress at the edge of the European world.

1070s

The Bayeux Tapestry, made of linen and embroidered with coloured woollen yarns, is created. It reveals hallmarks of Anglo-Saxon embroidery techniques.

680

Anglo-Saxon England has silk by the late 600s, brought back from Rome by Benedict Biscop and others. It is an essential, and portable, purchase for well-off pilgrims to Rome or the Holy Land.



▲ Eric depicted in 1688

1095

The First Crusade begins, opening additional routes and bringing back Eastern fabrics and styles to influence Europe.



► Byzantine fabrics travelled to Europe

711

The conquest of Spain by the Moors brings an Islamic and Moorish influence to Iberia and the development of Hispano-Moresque style (silk textiles that have geometric patterns).

1066

Beginning of the Norman Conquest in England, when Norman styles from the continent began to have a major influence on English dress.